to save. Then, seconds later, a cockpit warning light began flashing. *ENG CHIPS.*

Meaning: Land. Now.

Shit. We're going to have to put down in Taliban territory. I started thinking of Bodmin Moor.

Then I thought…maybe we could just ignore the warning light?

No, Dave was already turning us back to Bastion.

He was the more experienced flier. He'd already done three tours, he knew all about those warning lights. Some you could ignore—they blinked all the time and you pulled out the fuses to make them shut up—but not this one.

I felt cheated. I wanted to go, go, go. I was willing to risk crashing, being taken prisoner—whatever. Ours not to reason why, as Flea's great-granddad said, or Tennyson. Whoever. The point was: Unto the breach.

52.

I NEVER FULLY GOT OVER how fast the Apache was.

We'd usually cruise above a target area at a civilized 70 knots. But often, hurrying to the target area, we'd open her up, push her all the way to 145. And since we were barely off the ground, it felt three times faster. What a privilege, I thought, to experience this kind of raw power, and to put it to work for our side.

Flying super low was standard operating procedure. Harder for Taliban fighters to see you coming. Alas, easier for local kids to throw rocks at us. Which they did all the time. Children throwing rocks was about all the Taliban had in the way of anti-aircraft capability, other than a few Russian SAMs.

The problem wasn't evading the Taliban but finding them. In the four years since my first tour, they'd got much better at escaping. Humans are